COMMUNITY SUMMIT

Agents & Copilot



October 11–15, 2026
Gaylord Opryland Resort

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Turbocharge Your Backlog

GitHub Copilot + Azure DevOps MCP for faster story creation, review, and estimation

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Speakers



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Speakers



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BizApps Practice Lead

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Session Objectives

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1. Understanding of how GitHub Copilot and ADO MCP can streamline story creation, improve acceptance criteria, and identify gaps before development starts.
2. Apply an AI assisted workflow to reduce rework, improve cross-role collaboration, and assist in maintaining consistent work item documentation standards (leading to better product documentation).
3. Leave with a practical and repeatable process for story creation, triage, estimation, and backlog refinement.

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Session Agenda

01	**The Stack**	MCP, the Azure DevOps MCP server, VS Code vs CLI	**7 min**
02	**The Playbook**	Create · review · estimate, packaged as reusable files	**10 min**
03	**Live Demo**	Notes → estimated backlog for a Copilot Studio agent	**13 min**
04	**Governance**	Identity, scope, org controls, cost	**7 min**
05	**Evidence & Close**	What the research says, what's next	**5 min + Q&A**

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The backlog is the bottleneck

INTRO

01

Discovery is fast

Writing it down properly is the slow part.

02

Stories bounce

Missing acceptance criteria, too big, or vague ("As a user…").

03

Estimation stalls

On "what does this story even mean?"

04

Context leaks

Copy-paste between notes, chat tools, and Azure Boards.

THE IDEA

Let Copilot read and write your backlog directly, using your team's standards, with a human approving every write.

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SECTION 01 · 7 MIN

The Stack

How Copilot gets hands on Azure Boards



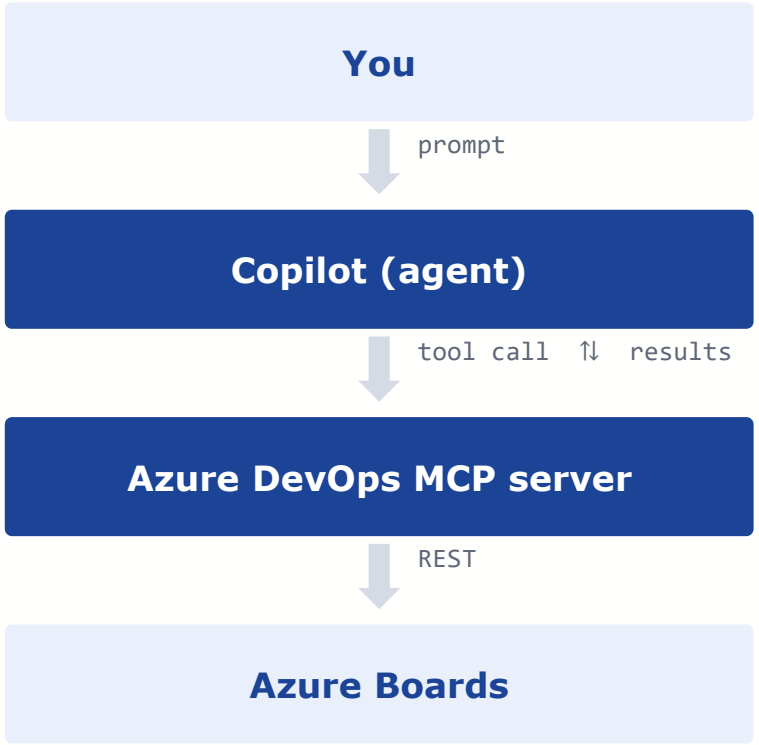
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MCP in 60 seconds

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01 · THE STACK

- **Model Context Protocol (MCP)** is an open standard for connecting AI assistants to tools and data.
- An **MCP server** exposes tools, e.g. "create work item", "run WIQL query".
- An **MCP client** (Copilot in VS Code, Copilot CLI, Visual Studio, Copilot Studio…) discovers the tools and calls them when the agent decides it needs them.
- **One server, many clients:** set up the Azure DevOps MCP server once and use it everywhere.



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The Azure DevOps MCP server has two flavors

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01 · THE STACK

	Remote server
Status	GA 5 Aug 2026
Runs	Hosted by Microsoft: `https://mcp.dev.azure.com/{org}`
Prereqs	Nothing to install
Auth	Microsoft Entra ID only (Entra-backed orgs)
Scoping	`X-MCP-Toolsets`, `X-MCP-Readonly` headers
Best for	Enterprise teams on Entra; zero install

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The tools that matter for backlog work

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01 · THE STACK

As of v2.9, related operations are merged into a few tools with an `action` parameter.

Tool	Actions you'll use	Domain
`wit_work_item`	`get · get_batch · list_for_iteration · get_type`	work-items
`wit_work_item_write`	`create · update · update_batch · add_child`	work-items
`wit_work_item_comment_write`	`add · update`	work-items
`wit_query`	`wiql · get_results`	work-items
`wit_backlog`	`list · list_work_items · reorder`	work-items
`work`	`list_team_iterations · get_team_capacity`	work
`core_list_projects · core_list_project_teams`	(single-purpose)	core
`search_workitem`	full-text search	search

HEADS-UP Seeing wit_create_work_item or wit_add_child_work_items in a blog? That's pre-v2.9 naming.

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Two cockpits: VS Code Agent mode vs Copilot CLI

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01 · THE STACK

	VS Code: Copilot Chat (Agent mode)	GitHub Copilot CLI
Feels like	Chat panel next to your files	Terminal-native agent
MCP config	`.vscode/mcp.json` (key: servers)	`~/.copilot/mcp-config.json` or `.github/mcp.json` (key: mcpServers)
Repo instructions	`copilot-instructions.md`, `*.instructions.md`, `AGENTS.md`	Same files
Custom agents	`.github/agents/*.agent.md`, picked in the agent dropdown	Same files, via `/agent` or `copilot --agent=<name>`
Prompt files	`.github/prompts/*.prompt.md → /create-stories`	Use the custom agent instead
Tool approval	Allow once / session / workspace / always	Yes / Yes for session / No · `--allow-tool` · `--deny-tool`
Best for	BAs & POs: visual, reviewable	Devs & automation: scriptable, fast

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Setup in VS Code (≈3 minutes)

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01 · THE STACK

.vscode/mcp.json

```
{
  "inputs": [{ "id": "ado_org", "type": "promptString",
               "description": "Azure DevOps org name" }],
  "servers": {
    "ado": {
      "type": "stdio",
      "command": "npx",
      "args": ["-y", "@azure-devops/mcp", "${input:ado_org}",
               "-d", "core", "work", "work-items", "search"],
      "env": { "ado_mcp_project": "Contoso Agents",
               "ado_mcp_team": "Case Status Team" }
    }
  }
}
```

1. **Save → Start**
   the server from the MCP view

2. **Agent mode**
   Configure Tools → confirm the ado tools

3. **Say hello**
   "List my ADO projects" → sign in when prompted

TIP Always include core in -d.

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Setup in Copilot CLI (≈2 minutes)

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01 · THE STACK

```
terminal

npm install -g @github/copilot   # needs Node.js 22+
copilot                          # then /login
```

```
~/.copilot/mcp-config.json  (or .github/mcp.json)

{
  "mcpServers": {
    "ado": {
      "type": "local",
      "command": "npx",
      "args": ["-y", "@azure-devops/mcp", "contoso",
               "-d", "core", "work", "work-items", "search"],
      "tools": ["*"]
    }
  }
}
```

OR INTERACTIVELY

`/mcp add`: name, type, command

`/mcp list`: check it loaded

`/mcp disable` · `/mcp edit`

GOTCHA

VS Code uses `servers`; the CLI uses `mcpServers`. Copy-paste between them and nothing loads.

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SECTION 02 · 10 MIN

The Playbook

Don't prompt. Package.



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Don't prompt, package: the starter kit

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02 · THE PLAYBOOK

```
your-repo/

├── .vscode/mcp.json
├── .github/
│   ├── copilot-instructions.md
│   ├── agents/
│   │   └── backlog-coach.agent.md
│   └── prompts/
│       ├── create-stories.prompt.md
│       ├── review-stories.prompt.md
│       └── estimate-stories.prompt.md
└── notes/   ← workshop notes, transcripts
```

INSTRUCTIONS

How we write stories. Always on.

AGENT

Who's helping: a persona with only the tools it needs.

PROMPTS

The repeatable jobs: one slash command each.

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copilot-instructions.md is your Definition of Ready

02 · THE PLAYBOOK

.github/copilot-instructions.md

```
## Azure DevOps backlog standards (Agile process)
- Work item types: Epic → Feature → User Story (not PBI).
- Description: "As a <specific role>, I want <goal>,
  so that <reason>." Never "As a user".
- Acceptance criteria: 3–6 Given/When/Then scenarios:
  happy path, ≥1 error case, relevant edge cases.
- INVEST. Anything > 8 points must be split.
- Story Points: Fibonacci 1-8, proposed, never final.
- Priority 1–4 · Value Area "Business" · Tag MVP for P1–P2.
- Technical chores are Tasks, not Stories.
- NEVER create or update work items without
  showing me the draft first.
```

READ THIS FIRST

The last line is the most important one.

SCOPE

Instructions apply to every chat in the repo, in VS Code and in the CLI.

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① Create: from notes to Epic → Feature → Story

02 · THE PLAYBOOK

VS Code chat

```
/create-stories #file:notes/discovery.md
```

1. Reads the notes and proposes an Epic, 3–8 Features, and Stories, in chat only
2. Lists open questions and assumptions the notes don't settle
3. Waits for you: "Approved. Drop 2.4, merge 3.1 and 3.2."
4. Writes with `wit_work_item_write`: create for the Epic, then add_child
5. Returns a table of new IDs and links

WIN

Structure, consistent wording, and full Given/When/Then, all generated in minutes.

WATCH

The AI fills gaps confidently. The open-questions list is where you catch that.

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② Review: an INVEST and AC lint before refinement

02 · THE PLAYBOOK

```
VS Code chat  ·  or an iteration, or a saved query

/review-stories Feature 1234
```

Check	Example flag
Independent	Depends on 1241 for the case lookup; consider merging or sequencing
Negotiable	Description prescribes the UI layout; move that to notes
Valuable	No "so that…" benefit
Estimable	Unclear which Dataverse table holds case status
Small	6 scenarios + 2 integrations; likely >8 pts, so split
Testable	AC #3 "works quickly" has no pass/fail threshold

OUTPUT

- A pass / warn / fail table in chat
- Review comments posted on the work item via `wit_work_item_comment_write`
- Proposed splits for oversized stories
- No field edits unless you approve

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③ Estimate: Copilot proposes, the team decides

02 · THE PLAYBOOK

Reference-class estimation: compare new work to your own finished work.

1. WIQL via `wit_query`: Closed User Stories with points, last ~6 months
2. Find the 2–3 most similar past stories
3. Propose Fibonacci points with rationale, analogs, confidence, risks
4. Take it into refinement / planning poker as a starting point
5. After the team agrees: `update_batch` sets Story Points

```
proposed estimate

Story 2.3 "Show case status by
           case number"
→ proposed 3   (confidence: medium)

Analogs:
  #812 Order status lookup     3
  #790 Account balance topic   3

Risk: auth for anonymous web-chat
      users not decided → could be 5
```

RULE The AI never sets the final number.

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The Backlog Coach custom agent

02 · THE PLAYBOOK

```
.github/agents/backlog-coach.agent.md

---
name: backlog-coach
description: Drafts, reviews, and estimates Azure DevOps
  backlog items using our standards.
tools: ['read', 'search',
  'ado/wit_work_item', 'ado/wit_work_item_write',
  'ado/wit_work_item_comment_write', 'ado/wit_query',
  'ado/wit_backlog', 'ado/work',
  'ado/core_list_projects', 'ado/core_list_project_teams']
---
You are a senior Business Analyst and Agile coach for a
Power Platform delivery team. Always draft in chat first
and wait for explicit approval before any write tool.
```

NARROW TOOL LIST

It can't touch repos, pipelines, or wikis. That's least privilege for AI.

SAME FILE, BOTH COCKPITS

VS Code agent dropdown, or `copilot --agent=backlog-coach`

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SECTION 03 · 13 MIN

Live Demo

Notes → estimated backlog, start to finish

LIVE DEMO · Switch to VS Code



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Demo scenario: the "Case Status Agent"

03 · LIVE DEMO • IN VS CODE

THE PROJECT

Contoso wants a Copilot Studio agent on its website and in Teams. Customers can check case status, add a comment, and escalate to a human. The agent is grounded in Dynamics 365 Customer Service.

INPUT

1 page of messy discovery notes

GOAL

A reviewed, estimated backlog in Azure Boards, live

Phase	Command	Tools that fire
Create	`/create-stories`	`wit_work_item_write` (create, add_child)
Review	`/review-stories`	`wit_work_item` · `wit_work_item_comment_write`
Estimate	`/estimate-stories`	`wit_query` (wiql) · `wit_work_item_write` (update_batch)

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Demo run sheet (12 minutes)

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03 · LIVE DEMO • IN VS CODE

Time	Beat	What the audience should notice
0:00	Raw notes + empty Azure Boards backlog	"This is what we usually start from"
0:30	Start stopwatch → `/create-stories #file:notes/…`	Draft in chat: Epic, 4–5 Features, ~12 Stories, open questions
3:00	Approve with one edit → tool prompt → Allow	The human-in-the-loop moment
4:30	Refresh Azure Boards	Parent/child links, AC filled, tags, priority
5:30	`/review-stories` on "Escalate to a human"	Pass / warn / fail flags + comments posted on the items
8:00	`/estimate-stories` for the new stories	Analogs from past closed stories, confidence, risks
10:30	Team agrees → approve update_batch → stop stopwatch	Story Points on the board
11:00	Compare: manual baseline ___ min vs today ___ min	Our live proof point

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Same flow, in the terminal

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03 · LIVE DEMO • SWITCH TO TERMINAL

```
terminal · case-status-agent

copilot --agent=backlog-coach \
  --prompt "Review all User Stories under Feature 1234 against our standards.
            Post review comments; do not edit fields."
```

- Same `copilot-instructions.md`, same agent, same ADO MCP server
- Approvals: Yes / Yes for this session / No. Script with `--allow-tool`, block with `--deny-tool`.
- Good for nightly backlog hygiene runs, bulk reviews, and devs who live in the terminal

VS CODE

Visual, collaborative. Great for the PO driving refinement.

CLI

Fast, scriptable. Great for the tech lead or automation.

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SECTION 04 · 7 MIN

Governance

Fast and safe



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Scope the blast radius

04 · GOVERNANCE

Layer	Control
Server	**Local:** `-d core work work-items` **loads only what you need · Remote:** `X-MCP-Toolsets: wit,work, X-MCP-Readonly: true`
Agent	`tools:` lists individual tools (`ado/wit_query`), not `ado/*`
Session	VS Code: approve each tool call; avoid `chat.tools.global.autoApprove` · CLI: `--deny-tool` for write tools
Instructions	"Never write without showing the draft first"
Process	New items tagged `ai-drafted`; review comments instead of field edits

START HERE Start read-only (review and estimate suggestions), then turn on writes once the team trusts the output.

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Org-level controls (for admins in the room)

04 · GOVERNANCE

MCP policy is OFF by default	"MCP servers in Copilot" for Business & Enterprise: an org or enterprise owner must enable it.
Registry allowlist	Set a registry URL (e.g. Azure API Center) and choose "Registry only" to block unapproved servers.
Copilot CLI policy	Must also be enabled for Business and Enterprise seats.
Data	GitHub doesn't use Copilot Business or Enterprise data to train its models.
Client support (remote)	VS Code, Visual Studio, Copilot CLI, Copilot Studio, and Foundry.

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Cost & human in the loop

04 · GOVERNANCE

LICENSING & COST

- Agent mode + MCP: Copilot Pro, Pro+, Max, Business, Enterprise (not Free)
- Since 1 Jun 2026, usage-based AI Credits (1 credit = $0.01)
- Agentic runs that read many work items use more tokens, so scope queries and pick the model
- Azure DevOps: Stakeholder (free) or Basic

HUMAN IN THE LOOP (NON-NEGOTIABLE)

✓ **Draft → approve → write**

✓ Estimates are proposals, set only after the team agrees

✓ The PO owns priority and acceptance; the AI never moves items across the board

✓ Retro question: "Did any AI-drafted story mislead us this sprint?"

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SECTION 05 · 5 MIN + Q&A

Evidence & Close

What we know, what's next



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What the research says (honestly)

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05 · EVIDENCE & CLOSE

55%

faster task completion

GitHub controlled experiment, 2022 (95 devs)

+26%

completed tasks

Microsoft/MIT/Princeton field experiments, 2025 (4,867 devs)

89% vs 66%

user stories meeting quality criteria, with a structured prompt

ICEIS 2025. A basic prompt was no better than manual.

~0.4

correlation of zero-shot LLM story points with actuals

arXiv 2026, 16 projects. Moderate at best.

19% slower

experienced devs, while believing they were faster

METR RCT, 2025

TAKEAWAYS **Structure beats prompts (hence the starter kit) · estimates are conversation starters · measure your own team**

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Where this is heading

05 · EVIDENCE & CLOSE

Remote server is GA

5 Aug 2026: no install, Entra sign-in, header-based tool filtering. Will eventually replace local.

Copilot app plugin

Azure DevOps plugin for the GitHub Copilot app (Aug 2026).

Copilot Studio is an MCP client

The same ADO server can power a Teams "backlog bot" for stakeholders.

Same tool names

Local and remote match, so your agents and prompt files carry over.

.vscode/mcp.json · the one-line migration

```
{ "servers": { "ado-remote": { "type": "http", "url": "https://mcp.dev.azure.com/contoso" } } }
```

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Thank you for Attending!



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